software engineer, explained, 'Just look at how respectfully [Modi] speaks to and about women. None of those pretentious, politically-correct, cutesy speeches, where they say something and do something else. Modiji says he cares about us and wants to protect us.'[21]

Women Protesters, Women Voters and Some Key Questions

This background raises critical questions about how the BJP as a party views women voters, its attitudes on gender-parity and the political impact of its women-focused strategies. These questions are critical, especially in light of the fact that it was women—from Delhi's Shaheen Bagh to Kolkata's Circus Maidan—who largely led and powered the anti-CAA protests that engulfed India between December 2019 and February 2020. By one count, women led at least 426 such protests nationwide (229 protest sit-ins, 119 rallies and eighty-seven protest marches).[22] The active involvement of so many women in protests against the government, such as the activists from the Pinjra Tod (Break the Cage) collective, which initially began in Delhi as a movement against restrictive hostel rules for women students,[23] further strengthened the general assumption that the BJP is a male-dominated and male-centric party, that it does not have the support of women and that support for the cultural right-wing is split along gender lines. This is a common enough assumption in the liberal discourse in India. It could not be more wrong.

The fact is that women accounted for 48.08 per cent of Indian voters in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. Almost every second voter was a woman.[24] The BJP could simply not be winning massive mandates without large numbers of women supporting it—that would be electorally impossible. Furthermore, as many as 67.17 per cent of women voters actually cast their vote in 2019—on par with the overall voting percentage of 67.4 per cent—and higher than the male turnout rate of 67 per cent.[25] In other words, women voters voted as much as men voters did in 2019. There was no gender divide in voter turnout patterns among registered voters. The BJP may ignore Muslim voters electorally—like it did in the UP elections of 2017—but